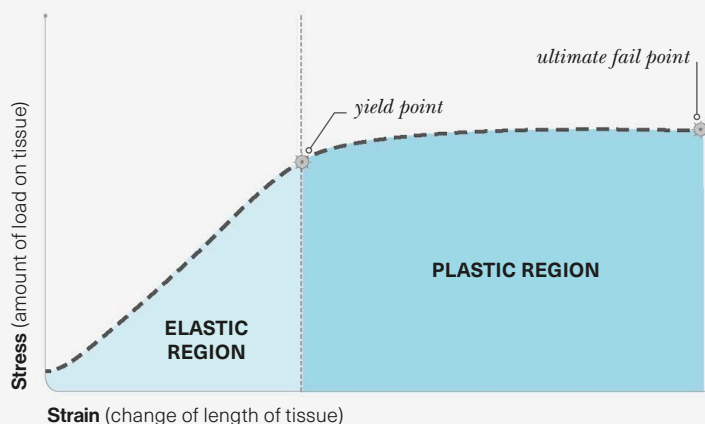


IS IT POSSIBLE TO STRETCH TOO MUCH?

Yes. There is a correlation between hypermobility—the ability to stretch beyond the normal range, or being “double jointed”—and chronic joint pain. When you stretch, you should feel the stretching sensation in the middle of the muscle, not near the joints, and you want to be able to breathe smoothly through the stretch. If you feel sharp or shooting sensations, numbness, pain, or anything that makes you grimace or hold your breath, you are overstretching. Overstretching lengthens your ligaments and/or tendons and, since they don't have much elasticity, they don't recoil well after they have been stretched. In other words, when the stress (load or stretch) on the tissue reaches the yield point it stops being “elastic” and becomes “plastic” (see above right). In clinical terms, this represents a tear. To

Stress-strain curve

This graph shows how much stress your tissue (muscle, tendon, or ligament) can take before injury. In the elastic region, the tissue can still return to its normal length when the stress is removed, but in the plastic region, it can't recoil. The ultimate fail point is a complete tear. To avoid injury, don't push beyond your limits.



avoid injury, it's best to strike a balance between using your yoga asana practice to improve your strength and using it to improve your flexibility.

MYTH-BUSTER

Hot yoga makes me more flexible.

It does, but only in the moment; it doesn't necessarily affect how flexible you are afterward. Higher temperatures raise your metabolic rate, warming your tissue quicker so you can stretch deeper. Practicing in hotter conditions makes it easy to stretch beyond your muscles' natural lengthening, which can lead to muscle damage (see above). Move slowly into poses with awareness to prevent injury.

